

The Bridal Session

Prep Guide.

Everything you need to know before you arrive.
So your session feels beautiful from the first frame.

- When to schedule your bridal session.
- Your gown — prep, transport, and what to practice.
- Hair and makeup — what looks best on camera.
- What to bring — the complete checklist.
- Location, light, and timing.
- The session day — exactly what to expect.

NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

“Genuine. Intentional. Timeless.”

nydamphoto.com · Austin, Texas · Est. 2008

WELCOME

Preparation Is *the Foundation.*

Not a formality.

The difference between good and unforgettable.

*“A bridal session is the one time before your wedding day
when everything is about you — unhurried, intentional, and complete.”*
NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

Your wedding day moves fast. Your bridal session doesn't. It's the one time dedicated entirely to you in your gown — without a timeline pressing, without guests waiting, without anything pulling your attention away from this.

The brides who get the most from their session are the ones who arrive prepared. They know what to expect, their gown is ready, their hair and makeup are set, and they've read this guide at least once. That preparation shows in every frame.

This guide covers everything: when to schedule, how to prepare your gown, what hair and makeup actually looks best on camera, what to bring, and exactly how the session will flow. Read it once. Follow the checklist. Then show up and let us take care of the rest.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- 01 When to Schedule →
- 02 Your Gown →
- 03 Hair & Makeup →
- 04 What to Bring →
- 05 Location & Light →
- 06 Your Session Day — What to Expect →

01

When to Schedule.

The timing of your bridal session affects everything — how relaxed you feel, how your gown looks, and what you can do with the portraits before your wedding day. Here's how to think about it.

THE IDEAL WINDOW

+ 2–4 weeks before your wedding.

Close enough that your gown alterations are complete and your look is finalized. Far enough that you're not exhausted or overwhelmed. This is the sweet spot for most brides.

+ Why not the morning of.

Wedding morning bridal portraits happen — and they're beautiful. But the timeline pressure is real. A separate session gives you unhurried time to move slowly, try things, and get the portraits you actually want.

+ After your final gown fitting.

Schedule the session only after your final alteration fitting is confirmed. You want to know the gown fits perfectly and the bustle works before you're in front of the camera.

+ After your hair and makeup trial.

If you're doing a hair and makeup trial — do it before the bridal session, not after. The session becomes a perfect second run of your wedding day look, on lower stakes.

+ Golden hour vs. midday.

We'll schedule your session around the best available light. For outdoor sessions, the hour before sunset is ideal — warm, directional, and flattering in any gown. Indoor and venue sessions are more flexible on timing.

+ How long to plan for.

Most bridal sessions run 1.5 to 2 hours. That gives us time for multiple locations or looks within a venue, gown detail shots, and a proper warm-up so the second half of the session is where the best images happen.

+ If you have a second dress.

Build in additional time — typically 30 minutes per outfit change. We'll plan the session sequence around the light and your locations so every look gets its best setting.

+ When to book.

Book your bridal session when you book your wedding with us. We'll hold the date and revisit the exact timing once your alterations and vendor schedule are confirmed closer to the date.

02

Your Gown.

Your gown is the centerpiece of the session. A little preparation before you arrive means it photographs at its best from the first frame — and you're not managing it instead of enjoying it.

BEFORE YOUR SESSION

+ Steam or press the day before.

Not the morning of. Give the fabric time to fall and settle naturally. A rushed press the morning of your session often leaves creases that show on camera, especially in satin and silk.

+ Hang overnight after steaming.

Hang your gown on a padded hanger in a clean, uncluttered space. Let it hang overnight after steaming so the fabric drapes the way it was designed to.

+ Know your bustle — practice it twice.

If your gown has a bustle, practice bustling and unbustling it before the session. Know which hooks connect to which loops. Bring someone who knows how to do it, or we can help on location.

+ Clean the hem.

Check the hem and train for any marks or debris from your fitting. Spot clean if needed. The train will be on the ground and close-up shots will show every detail.

+ Transport the gown properly.

Use a proper garment bag, not a plastic dry-cleaning bag. Lay it flat in the car if possible, or hang it from the hook above the rear door. Folded gowns arrive creased. Flat or hung gowns arrive ready.

+ Bring your full accessory set.

Veil, belt, sash, jewelry, shoes — everything. Even if you're not sure you want every piece in every shot, having options on location means we can make decisions in the moment based on what the light and setting call for.

+ Shoes matter more than you think.

Even if shoes are rarely in the frame, the right heel height affects your posture, your gait, and the silhouette of the gown. Wear the exact shoes you'll wear on your wedding day.

+ Bring a garment steamer if you have one.

For longer sessions or venue changes, a travel steamer in the car handles any wrinkles that appear in transit. It's not required — but brides who bring one are always glad they did.

03

Hair & Makeup.

Camera and mirror are not the same. What looks stunning in your bathroom and what photographs beautifully are close — but not identical. Here's what to know so your look translates perfectly.

Full wedding-day hair and makeup.

Come to your bridal session with the same hair and makeup you plan to wear on your wedding day — fully done, not a trial. This is a dress rehearsal for the real thing. Use it.

Your makeup trial first.

If you're working with a makeup artist, do your trial before the bridal session. The session becomes a perfect low-stakes test of how everything looks and holds on camera across hours.

Camera-ready foundation.

Matte or satin finish foundations photograph best. Dewy or luminous formulas can read as shine on camera, especially in controlled lighting. Ask your artist about this specifically.

Eyes over lips.

The camera reads eyes first. Defined brows, lifted lashes, and some depth in the crease make the biggest visible difference in portraits. Bold lip color is beautiful — but eyes carry the image.

Avoid heavy contouring.

Strong contouring that looks sculpted in the mirror can look heavy or patchy on camera, especially in directional flash lighting. Soft, blended definition photographs better than hard lines.

Hair hold matters.

Outdoor sessions in Austin involve wind. Use a light-hold product that allows some movement without turning into a veil-catching disaster mid-session. Bring it with you for touch-ups.

Touch-up kit is non-negotiable.

Powder, blotting papers, lip color, mascara, a small brush. You will need these between looks, especially in warm weather. We build brief touch-up pauses into the session — use them.

Waterproof everything.

If you're an emotional person — and bridal sessions can bring that out — waterproof mascara and liner are not optional. The best images sometimes come right after an unexpected moment.

Nails: clean and intentional.

Hands are in the frame more than most brides expect. Fresh nails — natural, gel, or polish — should be done before the session, not the morning of.

THE ONE RULE

Come fully done. Bring your touch-up kit. Waterproof your mascara.

04

What to Bring.

The complete checklist. Pack this the night before — not the morning of.

MUST-HAVES

- + **Your gown, steamed and hung.**
In a proper garment bag, transported flat or hung.
- + **Complete accessory set.**
Veil, belt, hair pieces, all jewelry you might wear. Every option.
- + **Wedding day shoes.**
Exact pair. Broken in if possible — at least walked in before the session.
- + **Bouquet or florals.**
Fresh, or a high-quality faux bouquet. The bouquet anchors your hands and adds color and texture to the frame. It matters.
- + **Touch-up kit.**
Powder, blotting papers, lip color, mascara, small brush, bobby pins.
- + **Water and a light snack.**
Not a meal — something small. Sessions run 1.5–2 hours and you will need it, especially outdoors in Texas.
- + **A trusted person.**
Someone to help with the bustle, hold your kit, and catch any dress or hair issues before we shoot. Your mom, your MOH, or your wedding coordinator.

OPTIONAL BUT SMART

- + **Travel garment steamer.**
For touch-ups in transit or between looks. Not required, always useful.
- + **A second look.**
A reception dress, a robe, a bridal jumpsuit. Adds variety and extends the creative range of the session.
- + **Something personal.**
Your grandmother's brooch, a letter from your partner, a heirloom. Objects with meaning make the most emotional detail shots.
- + **A playlist.**
Music that makes you feel like yourself. We'll have it playing. It changes the energy in the room.

LEAVE AT HOME

- + **Pets and small children.**
Unless planned in advance and specifically built into the session.
- + **Anyone who makes you nervous.**
This session is for you. An audience that creates self-consciousness works against what we're trying to create.
- + **Stress.**
Everything is handled. You just have to show up.

05

Location & Light.

Location and light are not separate decisions — they're the same decision. Where we shoot and when we shoot determine everything about how the images feel. Here's how we think about it.

LOCATION

+ Your wedding venue.

The most meaningful choice. Images made at the venue where you'll marry have a context that other locations can't replicate. We'll scout the specific spots — grand staircase, garden, chapel, courtyard — before the session.

+ A location personal to you.

Where you got engaged, a neighborhood you love, the restaurant where you had your first date. Personal locations produce the most emotionally authentic portraits.

+ An editorial Austin setting.

Austin has strong architectural and natural environments that work beautifully with a white gown: downtown archways, the Blanton terrace, Barton Creek, Hill Country cedar groves. We know them well.

+ Indoor studio or venue.

For brides who prefer controlled conditions or have a gown that needs a specific architectural context. We bring our own lighting — we're never dependent on the ambient.

LIGHT

+ The golden hour — our first choice outdoors.

The 60–90 minutes before sunset produces warm, directional light that is uniquely flattering to white fabric and skin tones. We schedule outdoor sessions to end at sunset.

+ Natural light and flash — almost always together.

We use both, almost always, even outdoors. Natural light sets the mood; flash fills shadows and ensures your face and gown are never competing with the sky. This is how every image stays clean and controlled.

+ Indoor light is not a limitation.

Venue interiors, chapels, grand halls — controlled lighting means we create exactly what the scene needs. A dark reception hall can produce some of the most cinematic bridal portraits.

+ Overcast days are underrated.

A fully overcast sky is a giant soft box. Even, diffused light with no harsh shadows. Don't reschedule because of clouds — call us first.

06

Your Session Day.

This is how a Nydam Photography bridal session actually flows — so nothing is a surprise when you arrive. Knowing the rhythm means you can relax into it instead of wondering what's next.

ARRIVE RELAXED — NOT RUSHED

Plan to arrive 10 minutes before your session start time, fully dressed and ready. Not still doing your hair. Not parking and running. Already in your gown, accessories on, touch-up kit in hand. Those first 10 minutes of arrival set the energy for everything that follows.

THE FIRST 15 MINUTES

We'll move slowly at the start — walking through the space, adjusting to the environment, letting your gown settle and your nerves do the same. No posed shots yet. The camera is running, but we're warming up. By the time we begin directing in earnest, the awkward phase is already over.

GOWN AND DETAIL WORK

We set aside dedicated time for gown detail shots — the train spread full, close-ups of the lace or beading, the veil against the light, rings, shoes, florals. These images are often the ones that become large wall pieces. We don't rush them. They require intention, not speed.

THE PORTRAIT SESSION

The middle hour is where we move through standing poses, walking, movement, veil work, and seated or ground-level portraits. Everything is directed — you will always know where to stand, where to look, and what to do with your hands. Refer to The Bridal Session Posing Guide for what to practice in advance.

THE SECOND HALF

This is where the best images of the session almost always happen. You're warmed up, the gown has been adjusted, and you've forgotten to think about what your face is doing. The session stops feeling like a session. We're still working. It just doesn't feel like it anymore.

AFTER THE SESSION

You'll receive a sneak peek within 48 hours. Your full edited gallery is delivered within 3–4 weeks, in time to use your favorites before the wedding — for rehearsal dinner displays, thank-you cards, or simply to have them.

*“We come prepared — every session planned with intention.
And then we create something real.”*

About Nydam Photography.

We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every session we do is personal. We arrive prepared — every session planned with intention — and we create something real.

We photograph with natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors — because the quality of the image matters more than the convenience of the approach. Every image is considered. Every detail is intentional.

GENUINE

Every portrait should feel like you — not a polished version of someone else. We create the conditions for real moments, then capture them.

INTENTIONAL

Light, posing, expression, timing — every element of a great portrait is considered in advance and guided with care throughout.

TIMELESS

We edit for longevity, not for trends. The images we create together are meant to stop you in your tracks ten years from now.

Weddings · Families & Portraits · Seniors · Sacraments · Quinceañeras · Events · Sports · Corporate Headshots & Branding

Every specialty. One standard of care.

KNOW SOMEONE WHO DESERVES THIS?

Pass this guide along — or send them directly to us. The right photographer changes everything. If you found yours — share that gift. A referral from a client is the highest compliment we receive.

With warmth,

Arlen and Tanya Nydam, Nydam Photography

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